Sunny Liang Tan (谭靓)

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References

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David Baqaee
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David Autor
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Jon Vogel
Professor of Economics
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Education

Oct 2021 -	**University of California, Los Angeles (UCLA)** Ph.D. in Economics Expected Graduation: Jun 2027	Los Angeles, CA
Sep 2024 - May 2025	**Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT)** Visiting Scholar	Cambridge, MA
Sep 2019 - May 2021	**Duke University** M.A. in Economics	Durham, NC
Sep 2015 - May 2019	**The University of Hong Kong** B.A. in Economics & Finance; Minor in Mathematics	Hong Kong

Research Fields

Primary: Macroeconomics, International Economics
Secondary: Development Economics, Industrial Organization
Research interests: Industrial Policy, Innovation Policy, Production Networks, GE Sufficient Statistics

Job Market Paper

Government Venture Capital, Production Networks, and Aggregate Productivity in China

Abstract: Industrial policy can reshape production well beyond the firms it directly supports, and assessing its aggregate productivity implications therefore requires measuring how supply-chain spillovers amplify or counteract recipient gains. This paper provides the first joint analysis of these direct, upstream, and downstream contributions in the setting of government venture capital in China. Linking investment records to firm accounts, patents, and supplier–buyer transactions, we identify expansion among financed firms and their existing trading partners. Suppliers expand sales and capital, while buyers expand sales and payroll. We combine these responses with baseline allocation statistics in a production-network framework that values both the resources absorbed by expanding firms and those released elsewhere. In the benchmark accounting with fixed industry factor supplies, supplier spillovers reinforce the recipient contribution, while the larger buyer contribution counteracts and more than offsets the positive recipient and supplier contributions at the point estimates. The analysis shows that

supply-chain spillovers can change both the scale and direction of the aggregate productivity contribution suggested by recipient outcomes alone, highlighting the value of considering production networks when evaluating industrial policy.

Working Paper

Exchange-Rate Movements and U.S. Corporations with Ivo Welch and Yuqing Zhou

Abstract: Linking U.S. Census export transactions to financial statements and stock returns for publicly traded U.S. exporters from 1992 to 2016, this paper revisits the exchange-rate exposure puzzle using firm-specific measures based on export destinations. Dollar depreciation is associated with higher exports, sales, profitability, and stock returns, with stronger exposure among larger and more export-oriented firms. In asset- or export-weighted specifications, a 1% depreciation is associated with approximately 0.4–0.6% higher exports and 0.6–0.8% higher sales, consistent with effects on domestic competitiveness as well as foreign demand. Operating sensitivities increase over time, while stock prices respond contemporaneously with no detectable delayed response around subsequent earnings announcements. The findings show that substantial corporate currency exposure can coexist with timely pricing.

Work in Progress

Industrial Policy and Scale Complementarities in EV Battery Supply Chains with Junjie Xia and Binkai Chen

Abstract: This project studies whether scale economies at successive production stages amplify industrial subsidies through mutually reinforcing demand and cost linkages in EV battery supply chains. Support for battery producers can increase demand for materials, allowing suppliers to lower unit costs; when passed downstream, these savings can induce further expansion. Using linked income-tax, VAT, and firm-to-firm transaction data, the analysis traces policy exposure through existing supplier relationships and examines suppliers' scale, costs, investment, and sales to other buyers. It distinguishes scale economies from changes in demand, markups, product composition, and supplier selection, and will discipline a production-network model to compare upstream, downstream, and joint support under a common fiscal budget.

Industrial Policy and Induced Innovation in Semiconductor Supply Chains with Meryvn Ho

Abstract: This project studies whether support for downstream chipmakers induces technological upgrading among semiconductor equipment suppliers. More advanced chip production raises equipment requirements, potentially making costly supplier innovation worthwhile, while repeated testing and customer feedback may generate learning that benefits subsequent buyers. Combining government venture capital investments, administrative firm data, supplier–buyer transactions, and fabrication-capacity and process-technology data, the analysis distinguishes customer capacity expansion from technological advances and examines how exposure duration and intensity shape supplier upgrading. It investigates whether new capabilities extend to other buyers and separates upgrading within incumbent suppliers from substitution toward suppliers that already possess advanced capabilities, tracing transferable learning beyond directly financed firms.

Teaching Experience

University of California, Los Angeles (UCLA)
Teaching Assistant, Principles of Economics (Winter 2024, Spring 2026)
Teaching Assistant, Microeconomic Theory (ECON 101; Fall 2022, Winter 2023, Fall 2023)
Teaching Assistant, Microeconomic Theory (ECON 11; Winter 2026)
Teaching Assistant, Ph.D. International Macroeconomics (Spring 2024)
Teaching Assistant, Competitive Strategy (elective; Spring 2023)

Duke University
Teaching Assistant, Ph.D. Econometrics II (Fall 2020)
Teaching Assistant, Econometrics and Data Science (Spring 2021)

Fellowships and Awards

2021–2027	UCLA Graduate Fellowship
2020	M.A. Merit Scholar Award, Duke University
2018	HKU Centennial Scholarship
2015–2016, 2017–2018	Dean's Honors List
2016	Hong Kong SAR Government Reaching Out Award

Presentations and Professional Service

- Presentation: South Cal International Macro Finance Conference, 2026.
- Presentation: West Coast Micro-to-Macro Development Workshop, 2026.
- Presentation: MIT Trade Lunch, 2025.
- Organizing Committee, Southern California Graduate Conference in Applied Economics, 2023.
- Initiator, UCLA Women in Economics, 2023-2025.

Research Experience

Jan 2023 - Feb 2023	**University of California, Los Angeles (UCLA)** Research Assistant to Jon Vogel Theoretical Analysis of Labor-Market Equilibrium	Los Angeles, CA
Sep 2021 - Nov 2021	**Duke University** Research Assistant to David Berger Literature Reviews and Data Construction on Wages and Taxes	Durham, NC
Jan 2021 - Jun 2021	**Duke University** Research Assistant to Matthew Masten Econometric Proof Summaries and Literature Reviews	Durham, NC
Nov 2018 - Jul 2022	**Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT)** Research Assistant to David Autor Occupational Data Digitalization, Classification, and Econometric Analysis	Cambridge, MA

Other Research Experience

Jan 2026 - May 2026	**SoftBank China Venture Capital** Data Collaboration China Artificial Intelligence and Energy	Hybrid
2023	**Price Theory Summer Camp**	Chicago
Jun 2017 - Jul 2017	**Bank of China (Hong Kong)** Summer Analyst Bond Connect Due Diligence / Regulatory Materials	Hong Kong
Dec 2016 - Jan 2017	**Muxin Asset Management (Shanghai)** Quantitative Research Intern A-Share Alpha Strategies / Foreign Exchange Research	Shanghai

Languages

Mandarin (native); English (fluent); Cantonese and Spanish (conversational)

Last updated: November 2026